■ Make sure your data is encrypted. Many sites use SSL, or secure sockets layer to encrypt information. Indications that your information will be encrypted include a URL that begins with https: instead of http: and a lock icon in the bottom right corner of the window.

■ In case you doubt the legitimacy of the certificate, refrain from entering any personal information. If the site does not require you to enter sensitive information, it probably won't display the lock icon.

■ Use a credit card instead of a debit card, because credit cards have pre-defined limits and in case your credit card details are compromised this will minimise possible losses. Use credit cards with a low credit line.

■ Check your statements to keep an eye on any unusual transactions

Cookies

While you browse the internet, information about your computer may be collected and stored fraudulently. To increase your level of security, adjust your privacy and security settings to block or limit cookies in your web browser. Make sure that other sites are not collecting personal information about you without your knowledge by choosing only to allow cookies for the web site you are visiting. Block or limit cookies from any third-party. If you are using a public computer, you should make sure that cookies are disabled to prevent other people from accessing or using your personal information. In such a case, if you had been using Firefox, press `[Shift] + [Ctrl] + [Del]` and use the dialogue box that pops up to clear all personal data and history. It is not so straightforward in Internet Explorer, but, depending on the version, you can do the same thing under the menu `Tools > Internet Options`.

Unsecured wireless networks

These pose a real security threat as seen from the recent misuse by terrorists to send email warnings about imminent terror attacks. Wireless networks allow criminals or hackers to intercept an unprotected connection. Wardriving involves individuals equipped with a computer, a wireless card, and a GPS device driving through areas in search of wireless networks and identifying the specific coordinates of a network location. Criminals with malicious intent could take advantage and access your computer and steal vital information or use your internet connection to commit acts of fraud or terror.

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Tips to secure wireless networks

■ Change the default passwords as most network devices have a pre-configured default password and these are easily found online.

■ Install a firewall directly onto your wireless devices (a host-based firewall). Attackers who directly intercept your wireless network may be able to by-pass your network firewall and so this does not offer sufficient protection.

■ Restrict access — only allow authorised users to access your network. Each piece of hardware connected to a network has a MAC (media access control) address. Restrict or allow access to your network by filtering MAC addresses. The MAC address is a unique identifier for networking hardware such as wireless network adapters. A hacker can capture details about a MAC address from your network and pretend to be that device to connect to your network. MAC filtering will still protect you from majority of the hackers. Find the MAC address for your network adapters on your devices by following these steps:

1. Go to `Start > Run`
2. Type `command` and press `[Enter]`
3. Type `ipconfig /all` in the command prompt window and press `[Enter]`
4. You can view the physical access address in the information displayed.

■ Check the user documentation to get specific information about the MAC Filtering process if you have any more queries.

■ Encrypt the data on your network. Encrypting the data would prevent anyone who might somehow be able to access your network from viewing your data.

■ Protect your SSID (Service Set Identifier — An SSID is the name of a WLAN). The SSID on wireless clients can be set either manually, by entering the SSID into the client network settings, or automatically, by leaving the SSID unspecified or blank. A network administrator often uses a public SSID that is set on the access point and broadcast to all wireless devices in range. You can disable the automatic SSID broadcast feature to improve network security.

■ To avoid outsiders from easily accessing your network, avoid publicising your SSID. Consult user documentation to see if you can change the default SSID to make it more difficult to guess.

Secure your web page

■ Normally, when browsing the web, URLs begin with the letters http. However, over a secure connection, the address displayed should begin with https.

Spoofing attacks

■ Spoofing attacks are as common as phishing frauds. The spoofed site is usually designed to look like the genuine site, using a similar look and feel to the legitimate site. The best way to verify whether you are at a spoofed site is to verify the certificate.

■ "Lock" icon – check for the lock icon in the lower-right of the browser window. This tells you that the web site uses encryption to protect sensitive personal information — credit card number, ATM PINs, Social Security number, etc. The lock only appears on sites that use an SSL connection, which is typically used only on sites where you enter sensitive information. The secure site lock icon when closed means that the site uses encryption. Double-click the lock icon to display the security certificate for the site. This certificate is proof of the identity for the site. While checking the certificate, the name following "Issued to:" should match the site you are on. In the event of the names not matching, you are on a spoofed site and should quit.

What is 128-bit SSL?

SSL stands for "Secure Sockets Layer". It is a protocol designed to enable applications to transmit information back and forth securely. SSL is accepted on the world wide web for authenticated and encrypted communication between the computer and servers.

Identity theft could result from both offline and online fraud. Offline frauds occur as a result of theft of your mails, credit cards, debit cards, and cheque books. You should be cautious while receiving, storing and disposing information pertaining to cheques, ATM / debit and credit cards. Identity theft can happen even to those who do not shop, communicate, or transact online.

Can others on the internet access my information?

Only if a secure session is established and the information is encrypted during transmission, are you safe. However, some web browsers store information on your computer even after you have finished surfing. This phenomenon is called caching. Close your browser once you have finished surfing, especially secure sites to conduct financial transactions.

Disable active content

Web sites use scripts that execute programs within the web browser. This active content can be used to create "splash pages" or drop-down menus. These scripts are used by hackers to download or execute viruses on a user's computer. However, you can prevent active content from running in most browsers resulting in limiting some functionalities and features of some web sites. Therefore, before clicking on a link to a web site that you are not familiar with or do not trust, disable active content.

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Safeguarding online trading

The risks involved in online trading are high. Brokerages have information about you and this information is under attack by fraudsters. To gain access to these databases, attackers may use trojan horses or other types of malicious code.

Tips to safeguard online trading

■ You should thoroughly check the brokerages you are trading with.

■ Check through offline methods about brokerages.

■ Check privacy policies of the site you are trading with.

■ Check about the legitimacy of the web site by checking their certificates.

■ Check your accounts regularly for any suspicious or unusual transaction.

Counterfeit Web sites

Often you are guided to fraudulent web sites via email and pop-up windows in order to collect your personal information. You can detect such web sites if you type the said URL into a new browser window. If it does not take you to a legitimate web site, or you get an error message, it is a fake web site. Never click on a link in an email to a site involving financial transactions. Either enter the URL by hand, or you will likely already have your bank, eBay and other such sites bookmarked. Use those links instead.

Some Downloading tips

■ Download programs from legitimate and trustworthy sites. Enter the program in a search engine to check whether the program has been reported for spyware issues.

■ Be cautious when downloading free music, movies, software, and surfing file sharing sites.

■ Read the privacy statements and licensing agreements of the software you download

■ Never enter financial information in pop up windows. ■